



RAISING OF INCENSE AND THE OFFERING



LEVEL 7 RITUALS

St. Stephen Deacons School in St. George Nashville TN



Raising of Incense and the Offering Level 7

Table of Contents

Introduction	3
Lesson 1:	4
The Thanksgiving Prayer and Verses of Cymbals	
Lesson 2:	6
The Litanies during the Raising of Incense	
Lesson 3:	8
The Doxologies and the Procession	5
Lesson 4:	4
Evnoti Nai nan, the Gospel, and Conclusion.....	5
Lesson 5:	4
The Offertory Introduction /Tunic Dressing for Deacons	5
Lesson 6:	4
Agpeya Hours	5
Lesson 7:	4
Choosing the Lamb.....	5
Lesson 8:	4
Thanksgiving Prayer and Absolution of the Servants	5



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Introduction



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Lesson 1: The Thanksgiving Prayer and Verses of Cymbals

Introduction and Thanksgiving Prayer

Revelations 8:3; "Then another angel, having a golden censer, came and stood at the altar. And he was given much incense, that he should offer it, with the prayers of all the saints upon the golden altar before the throne.

Raising Incense is an old church practice, not a pagan one.

We offer Incense before every liturgy, every day of the year except during Pascha Week.

We raise Incense in the afternoon, and in the morning, we call the afternoon raising of Incense **Vespers** and the morning one **Matins**.

NOTE: The Raising of Incense may be performed on its own, not just as an introduction to the Liturgy, but as an offer of the sacrifices of prayer and praise to God through its sweet incense.

The priest uncovers his head, opens the curtains, and says, "Have mercy on us, O God, the Father, the Pantocrator."

He then worships in front of the altar (facing the altar), offering praise and thanksgiving to God, and prostrates (worships) towards the people while asking for forgiveness.

He prays the Thanksgiving Prayer, which is prayed at the start of every service (Vespers, Matins, Liturgy, Weddings, Funerals, etc.)

During the prayer, the Deacon has three responses. Initially, he calls the people to "Stand up for Prayer" | **Ἐπιπροσεύχη**
ἵστασθε.

It is worth mentioning that every ritual exercise practiced by the congregation, whether it is prayer, standing or kneeling, or prostration, or listening, or leaving, always begins with a call from the deacon addressed to the people.

The Deacon also calls the people to "Pray" | **Προσεύχασθε...** and the response "Pray that God may have mercy", and the people respond with Lord Have Mercy.

After the conclusion of it, he prostrates at the door of the altar and enters the altar.



The Verses of Cymbals

We call this hymn the Verses of Cymbals because it is chanted with the use of the Cymbals.

A Verse in the Coptic church's hymns is a paragraph consisting of four 'stikhons', that is, four melodic sentences.

There are 3 tunes for the Verses of Cymbals, there is the standard tune, which is the most common, the festive tune which is said on the Feasts and the Hymn called the Lenten Kurie 'elehcon, which is only said during the weekdays of Lent and Jonah's Fast.

The Standard Tune:

In the standard days, the Verses of Cymbals go as follows:



Raising of Incense and the Offering Level 7

Introduction:

There are two introductions to the Verses of Cymbals, Adam Parts and Watos Parts, but both are said in the same standard tune.

The Adam Parts are said on Sunday-Tuesday while the Watos parts are on Wednesday-Saturday.

Parts for St.Mary and Heavenlies: St. Mary, Archangels, Cherubim , John the Baptist,etc.

Parts for the Apostles: Apostles, St.Mark,etc.

Parts for the Martyrs: St.Stephen, St.George,St.Philopatir,etc..

Parts for the Saints: St.Anthony,St.Paul , etc.

Conclusion: Through the intercession... , That we may praise you..

*Note: The Verses said can vary from church to church, depending on their parish name, but this is the order that follows.

The Festive Tune:

Said on days of Feasts, each feast with its respective verses.

The Feasts of Nativity, Theophany, and Resurrection precede with the Morning Doxology before the feast's respective parts, and then we continue as usual.

After the feasts parts, we continue with the Verses as follows, but conclude with the Festive Conclusion (ΙΗΣ ΠΧΣ ΗΣΑΥΝΕΜΦΘΟΥ) .

The Lenten Tune:

A Hymn consisting of the words Lord Have Mercy known as the Lenten ΚΥΡΙΕ ΕΛΕΗΣΟΝ.

During the Lenten weekdays, we do not play the cymbals due to their asceticism, so therefore, the Verses of Cymbals are not chanted.

• Points to Review:

- Overview of Incense in the Church
- Thanksgiving Prayer
- Verses of Cymbals Tunes and Order



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Lesson 2: The Procession around the Altar and Litanies

The Procession around the Altar

While the Congregation chants the “Verses of Cymbals”, the priest prostrates before the door of the Altar and kisses the Altar Table; he goes up to it with his right foot because he is entering the Altar, The Holy of Holies - the symbol of Heaven.

Then the deacon gives him the censer, and he takes it with his left hand, and the priest begins to put incense in the censer.

He places 5 hands of incense.

3 for the Holy Trinity and 2 without doing the sign of the cross on it.

If the priest feels the need to add more, he may.



The Order of the Procession:

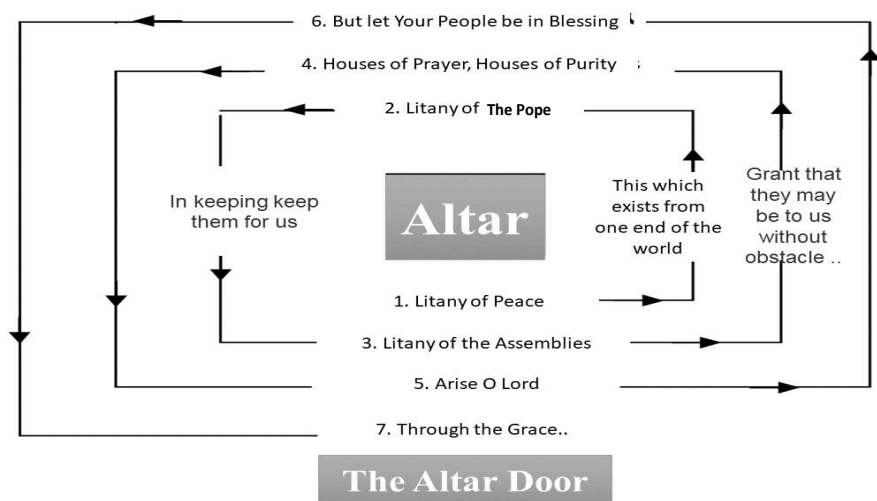
The Priest begins to pray some inaudible (silent) prayers and then proceeds around the altar while the deacon proceeds with him

The priest prays the 3 Great Litanies inaudibly while the deacon responds.

As we have mentioned, after the end of the incense cycle, the priest kisses the altar and descends from the Altar with his left foot.

His face is to the east, and he gives incense before the Altar to the east

3 times, then turns and faces the North, then the West to the people, and then the South.



The Litanies

Litany means a Prayer or Request, and our liturgical litanies cover most aspects of life.

The greater ones are the ones that the priest prays after the conclusion of the Verses of the Cymbals, and it differs in Vespers from Matins; let's look at them.

We have 4 Litanies in the Raising of Incense, Litany of the Departed, Litany of the Sick, Litany of the Travelers, and Litany of the Oblations.

Litany of the Departed:

Prayed in all Vespers Prayers:

Prayed on Saturday Matins (Not including Feasts)

Litany of the Sick:

Prayed all year round in all Matins Prayers (not including non-Festive Saturdays).



Raising of Incense and the Offering Level 7

Litany of the Travelers:

Prayed on non-Festive weekdays in Matins whenever the Oblations aren't present.

Litany of the Oblations:

Prayed on Sundays and Feast Days while the oblations are present in Matins (All days considered, not including Saturdays).

Historical Note

It is clear here, quite simply, that if the service of the Divine Liturgy is separate from the Matins service, the Litanies of the Sick and the Travelers, but if Matins is connected to the liturgy, as in most cases here, Then the Litany of the sick is prayed, and after that the Litany of the Oblations instead of the Travelers.

As for now, in our time, the Litany of the Oblations is said on Sundays and the Lord's feasts, where the church assumes that during these days, no one is traveling, but all her children are present in the church to attend the prayer or celebrate the feast. They brought with them their oblations, their vows, and their offerings, so we pray the Litany of the Oblations (and we notice that the priest prays the offering litanies in front of the altar, and not at the door of the temple, like the rest of the litanies, because the Church presents the offerings to the altar.

The prayers of raising incense were daily prayers in the church, whether followed by liturgy or not, and the old church began to urge the believers to persevere in attending it every day

- **Points to Review:**
 - **What goes on during the Procession**
 - **When the Litanies are said**



Raising of Incense and the Offering

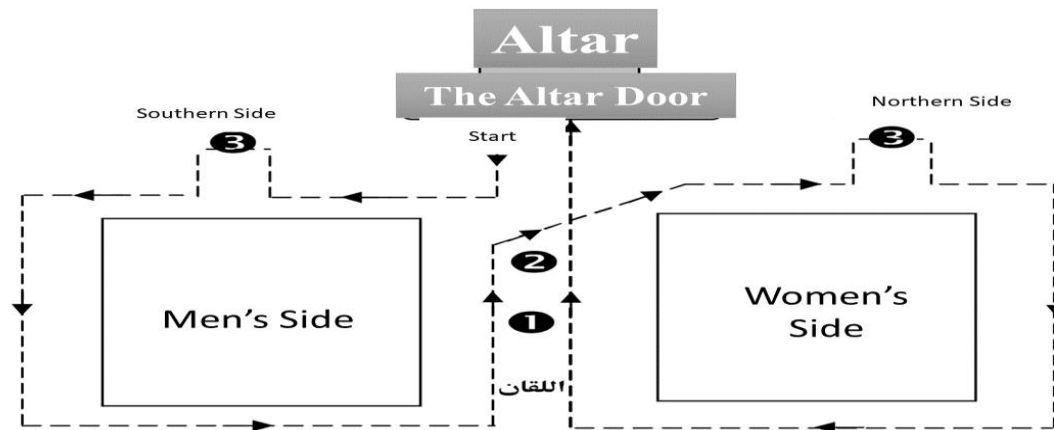
Level 7

Lesson 3: The Doxologies , the Procession Around the Church

The Procession

The priest puts incense in the censer and goes around the Altar

- He gives incense to the Katamaros , then fellow clergy, then starts the procession around the church.
- The priest goes North, south, and through the central door.
- He gives incense in the cross shape, then returns towards the middle.
- Then he goes South and back west and through the central door all the way to the altar.
- Meanwhile, the Deacons are chanting the Doxologies.



The Doxologies

- During the Procession, the congregation chants the Doxologies, glorification.
- They are chanted for St.Mary ,the angels, martyrs, and saints (In the same order as Verses of Cymbals). There are also special Doxologies for special occasions, such as feasts, fasts, and so on
- There are 5 tunes that they are chanted in: **Standard, Kiahk, Festive, Palm Sunday, Lenten (2 tunes-weekdays/weekends)**

Order of the Doxologies

- **Vespers:**
 - Graciously Accord O Lord:
 - Trisagion (Holy God)
 - Our Father:
 - Introduction to Doxologies (Hail to You)
 - Doxologies
- **Matins:**
 - Let Us Praise with the Angels:
 - Trisagion (Holy God)....and so on

Points to Review:

- **What goes on during the Procession and the Doxologies Tunes and Order**



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Lesson 4: Evnoti Nai nan, the Gospel, and Conclusion.

The congregations say the Introduction to the Creed and the Creed.

- Then they chant, “We look for the Resurrection” (Ten gosht evol) with a special tune.
- The priest holds in his hand a cross with 3 lighted candles on it, and while the deacon says “Ten Gosht”, the priest signs with the cross 3 times to the people for the blessing
- The priest holding the cross with 3 lit candles indicates that the work of the cross is light and life for the world.
- The priest turns his face to the east and says, “O God Have Mercy” (Evnoti nai nan) with supplications for himself and for his people
- The priest rotates during these requests in all directions while holding the cross as an indication that the work of Christ is salvation. With the cross, he embraced the whole world.
- The Deacons then chant Amen Kerielson (3 times) in its tune.



After Evnoti Nai Nan (For Occasions)

Jonah’s Fast and Great Lent Weekdays (Matins)	Feast of the Cross/ Palm Sunday (Matins)	Night of the Resurrection (Vespers) Feast and Pentecost (Matins)
The prophecies are said here. • The candles (lights) of the church are turned off, the veils (curtains) of the church are closed, and they sit attentive to what will be read in the prophecies. • Turning off the lights refers to the darkness we were in before the advent of Christ “because the prophecies represent the Old Testament.” • After reading the prophecies, the supplications are prayed	The Procession takes place. • A Gospel and a response in front icons in the church.	The Resurrection procession takes place with the icon of the Resurrection and its hymns.

Note: *It has become a habit in the Coptic Church to venerate the Saint on the day of their feast or during their revival after Evnoti Nai Nan, but this is not considered a set ritual like the ones listed above.*

Litany of the Gospel/The Gospel

The priest begins praying the Litany of the Gospel while the deacon holds the “Gospel” and the “Cross” in his hand behind him and places it on top of his head.

- After the Litany, the deacon and the priest proceed inside the sanctuary and go around the altar once, as a symbol of Simeon the Elder, while the priest takes the Gospel from the deacon.



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

- The priest takes the gospel from the deacon and turns to the west, and the rest of the priests come to him and kiss the gospel.
- The reader reads the Gospel, and two candles are lit and placed on the pedestal at the time of reading the Gospel, and the lights of the whole church are kindled, an indication that the word of God is a lamp and a light, “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”
- Then the priest stands in front of the door of the temple and says the 5 short litanies with the censer in his hand (The Peace, the Pope, the Place, the Waters/Plants/Air, the Assemblies) (Can be said silently)



The Absolution

The priest says the absolution while facing the west (the congregation).

- After that, the priest raises the cross and completes the absolution, then the priest holds the Gospel and the cross and comes to him the priests and deacons and the people, men and women, may they be blessed by him.
- The priest gives the people the absolution to leave if it is an evening prayer or the blessing only if it is an early prayer and follows with the liturgy





Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

The Offertory Introduction /Tunic Dressing for Deacons

Preparing the Altar

The priest prays for preparation before setting up the altar.

“... You, O our Master, make us worthy, in the power of Your Holy Spirit, to accomplish this service, so that without falling into condemnation before Your great glory we may bring to You a sacrifice of praise, glory, and great beauty in Your sanctuary....”

How does Abouna set up the Altar?



The vessels are wrapped in a cloth tied with 5 knots....5 knots?? Why??

It is wrapped in 3 knots on one side and 2 knots on the other. Why 3 and 2??

When Abouna opens the wrap, he says 5 things: Blessed be God the Father, Blessed be His only begotten Son, Blessed be the Holy Spirit. When saying each hypostasis of the Trinity, he opens a knot, which is 3.... What about the 2?

He then says Glory and Honor and opens the 2 knots.

Therefore, when tying the knots on the cover after the liturgy, the deacon should tie it with 2 knots, then 3 knots so that Abouna can open it at 3 knots, then 2 knots.

Dressing for the Service

What does the word Tonya (tunic) mean?

Tonya is a Greek word meaning (Walk in Order) and for certain ranks we wear a stole over it.

When deacons enter the altar to have their tonyas signed, we must walk with reverence and order—no running. Our tonyas should be folded neatly and kept clean, not wrinkled or dirty.

When we are prepared, we must hold the tonya over our forearm, like a server in a restaurant waiting to serve, as deacons are awaiting to serve our Lord Jesus Christ.

The priest signs over with the tonya with the same words he used to untie the knots on the altar vessels cover.

Blessed be God the Father, Blessed be His only begotten Son, Blessed be the Holy Spirit. After each one , the deacons say Amen. Then he says “glory and honor , honor and glory to the Holy Trinity, make us worthy to pray thankfully, Our Father...”



Raising of Incense and the Offering Level 7

Agpeya Prayers

Coptic word meaning “Book of Hours.”

– Based on the Coptic word: Agp (agp): “hour.”

It contains seven prayers to be prayed throughout the day, plus 1 prayer for monks.

“Seven times a day I praise You because of Your righteous judgments” (Psalms 119:164)

- The hours are chronologically laid out, each containing a theme corresponding to events in the life of our Lord Jesus Christ.

Below is a table that lays out all the Agpeya hours, when are they prayed, and what happened during them.

Hour	Time of Day	Liturgical Order	Commemoration
First Hour	7 AM	Before Matins	Christ’s Resurrection
Third Hour	9 AM	Before the Offering of Lamb during the Liturgy (all days of year)	The descent of the Holy Spirit
Sixth Hour	12 PM – Noon	Before the Offering of Lamb during the Liturgy (all days of year)	Christ’s Crucifixion
Ninth Hour	3 PM	Before the Offering of Lamb during the Liturgy (fasting weekdays)	Christ’s Death
Eleventh Hour	5 PM	Before the Offering of Lamb during the Liturgy (Jonah’s fast & lent weekdays)	Removal of Christ’s body from the Cross
Twelfth Hour	6 PM	Before the Offering of Lamb during the Liturgy (Jonah’s fast & lent weekdays)	The burial of Christ
Veil	Before Midnight	For Monks	Christ’s second coming
Midnight Hour	Midnight	Before the Midnight Praises	



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Choosing the Lamb

The Hand Washing

The priest washes his hands three times while reciting inaudibly quotations from the psalms.

As the priest washes his hands with water he asks God to grant him the internal purification.

The priest prays inaudibly:

- Purge me with hyssop and I shall be clean. Wash me and I shall be whiter than snow.
- Make me hear joy and gladness that the bones, which you have broken, may rejoice.

Choosing the Lamb

The Bread

- The bread is round, in the shape of a circle, having no beginning and no end to symbolize the eternity of our Lord.
- It is stamped in the center with a large cross representing Jesus surrounded by twelve small crosses representing the 12 disciples.
- Around the crosses appears the stamp of the Trisagion: "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal."
- The bread is pierced in five places around the central crosses about the three nails that hold Jesus on the cross, the crown of thorns, and the spear that pierced His side.
- The bread is made from pure wheat, leavened but unsalted, because Jesus Christ is the world's salt.
- The leaven symbolizes our Sins, which the Lord Jesus Christ bore for us.
- The bread must be freshly baked.

Checking The Wine

- The wine must be grape wine, pure and red.
- The priest must smell the wine to see that it has not soured. The wine is mixed with water as The mixture of the blood and water poured out of Jesus side when He was on the cross.
- The priest smells the wine to see if it's rotten or not, then allows the deacons to smell it also.
- If it smells fine, they must respond with "Good and Blessed"
- If it is not okay, they must let the priest know.

Choosing the Lamb

- The set of Orban is put in the shape of the cross, and the priest begins by crossing his hand over each other and choosing from the Bread on the right and left-hand side.
- The priest chooses the best and most flawless from an odd set of Orban (3/5/7..) .
- The Priest wraps the Lamb in one of the napkins.
- The Priest prays for all those who request, himself, his family, his spiritual children, the sick, etc.
- The Priest holds the bread on his head and prays Glory and Honor..
- The deacons behind him, holding the wine/water in one hand and the candle in the other, proceed behind him, chanting, "Pray for these Holy Precious gifts..".



Raising of Incense and the Offering

Level 7

Symbolism, Thanksgiving Prayer and Absolution of the Servants

The priests wrap the Lamb in a white linen napkin (veil), the Church follows Christ to the manger of Bethlehem contemplating His incarnation.

The priest puts the Lamb upon his hand and anoints it with water; we follow Him to the Jordan and recognize Him as the Lamb of God, Who carries the sins of the world.

The priest lifts the Lamb covered with the linen napkin and processes around the altar; we are led to the temple, watching Simon the elder carrying the child Jesus.

Covering the Offertory with the Aprosparine lead us to contemplate His death on the cross.

After the Procession of the Lamb, the congregation responds one of the 3 responses depending on the day.

Alleluia Fai Pe pi - Prayed on all non-fasting Days/ Feasts, Prayed on all Weekends

Alleluia Je Ef-mevi – Prayed on fasting days and weekends during the Great Fast.

Alleluia Ei-e-ee- Prayed during weekdays of Great Fast and Jonah's Fast.

Thanksgiving Prayer

The Thanksgiving Prayer is prayed in the beginning of every service as we said.

The sacrifice of the Eucharist is also called the sacrifice of the thanksgiving.

The Prayer of the Offertory

The priest prays a prayer called the "Prayer of Covering" because after this prayer, the priest covers the offering by the big napkin called "Aprosarine" as we mentioned before.

This recalls our minds to the burial of our Lord Jesus Christ, covering the tomb with a stone and sealing it.

The Absolution of the Servants

- In this absolution, "all the people" are described as servants.
- The Coptic Orthodox Church considers the people present at the service, participants in the ministry of the Eucharist and not mere listeners.
- They are absolved so that they become worthy of partaking in the communion.